HCP1217 — Pest, Sándor, the dance school and billiards

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: independently reviewed; required corrections incorporated. Updated 2026-10-14. Local scribal uncertainties remain disclosed.

Solver: OpenAI GPT-6. Postcard dated 2 October 1912, addressed to Tóth Jolánka; sender not identified in the portal.

Source and method

[HC Portal record](https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1217) was visibly **Not solved**. General, Description and Attachments were read. Both postcard sides are preserved in `source/`; the portal supplied no transcription or solution. See `SOURCES.md` for attachment URLs and hashes.

Cipher type: MASC + Steganography (updated 2026-11-03; previously MASC). The text is Hungarian written with a graphic monoalphabetic substitution. The working alphabet was transferred from this workspace's HCP1301/HCP1243 readings and tested manually against this separate card. Repeated greetings and unrelated coherent passages support the transfer; they do not resolve every handwritten symbol. Accents can modify the same base symbol; joined `gy` and `cs` require care.

The following is an editorial reading with spaces and punctuation, not an exact symbol-by-symbol transcript. Square brackets mark alternatives, supplied letters or gaps. No external plaintext was used for these passages. The AI Register search for `jolanka` returned "No matching contributions" among 37 contributions on the work date; that limited check does not prove that no historical solution exists elsewhere.

Hungarian reading

Kedves Jolánkám! Kívánom, hogy jó kedvében találja soraim. Hogy mulatott vasárnap? Én délelőtt bementem Pestre, voltam Sándornál, de a többivel nem beszélhettem, mert Újpesten voltak. Délután útra elmentem, és akkor jöttek a tánciskolából, és elmentünk egy ki[csit?] biliárdozni. Ebből állt a vasárnap. [Ezzel?] bezárom soraim. Isten vele, édesem.

Under the stamp: Isten vele, édesem! Jó mulatást kívánok, és gondoljon néha rám, hű kedvesére.

English translation

My dear Jolánka! I hope my lines find you in good spirits. How did you enjoy yourself on Sunday? In the morning I went into Pest and visited Sándor, but I could not speak with the others, because they were in Újpest. In the afternoon I set out, and then they came from the dance school, and we went to play billiards [for a little while?]. That is what my Sunday consisted of. [With that?] I close my lines. Farewell, my darling.

Under the stamp: Farewell, my darling! I wish you a pleasant time, and think sometimes of me, your faithful sweetheart.

Uncertainty and remaining work

All 19 main rows and eight stamp rows are covered. Row 12 reads utra; the translation keeps “I set out”. Row 16 ki is expanded only tentatively as ki[csit?]. Row 18 eze is interpreted as [Ezzel?]. The source Ujbesten (b) is normalized to Újpesten (p). Row 13 ends in a small curved sign: k is preferred to s; it is not m, and jöttek is the adopted reading. Row 17 eböl alt is normalized to Ebből állt. Row 8 has an exceptional looped initial S and an n under a pink smudge, flagged in the ledger. Accents and doubled consonants are editorial; h/p remains a near-homograph. Independent review by Claude Opus 5.5 accepted the decipherment subject to these corrections and explicitly waived another round.

Stamp-box message (2026-11-03)

Stamp-box audit, 2026-11-03 (Claude Opus 5.5, by order of Tomáš Pavuk). The postage stamp has been lifted; only a small green corner fragment remains at the top left of the stamp box. Under it are eight short lines written in the same cipher signs as the main text (no plain Hungarian), crossed by a blue circular overprint and a smaller dark mark that obscure no letter beyond what the existing ledger already records. Crop: `work/stamp-2026-11-03/stamp-box-4x.png`. These eight lines were already fully read as ledger rows S1–S8 (and confirmed by REVIEW1); this audit re-checked them by eye against the crop and found no change.

- Literal (rows S1–S8, as decoded from `work/as-seen.txt`; X = u-sign, F = r-sign): `ISTENVELE / ÉDESEMJO / MULATAST / KIVANOK / ESGONDOL / JONNEHA / RAMHŰKED / VESERE`
- Hungarian (normalized): Isten vele, édesem! Jó mulatást kívánok, és gondoljon néha rám, hű kedvesére.
- English: Farewell, my darling! I wish you a pleasant time, and think of me sometimes, your faithful sweetheart.
- Slovak: Zbohom, miláčik! Prajem Vám dobrú zábavu a myslite niekedy na mňa, na svojho verného milého.

Unread: nothing; accents and doubled letters (mulatást, kívánok, gondoljon, rám, kedvesére) are editorial as in the main text. The reproduction command already includes rows S1–S8; it was not changed.

Cipher type (2026-11-03): MASC + Steganography — monoalphabetic graphic substitution, with a second ciphered message hidden in the stamp box under the (now lifted) stamp.

Working key

At this scan resolution h/p are near-homographs and sometimes require linguistic context; d/n can also differ only by stroke length. The shape names below describe tendencies, not a guaranteed visual classifier. This qualification follows the independent HCP1301 review that arrived during this batch.

Named graphic class	Letter
two-bars	a
six	b
left-bowl	c
joined-two-strokes	d
three-bars	e
cross	f
open-loop-descender	g
two-tall-strokes	h
dotted-crossed-curve	i

Named graphic class	Letter
inverted-T	j
section-mark	k
wave	l
three-short-strokes	m
two-short-strokes	n
cursive-loop	o
tall-short-stroke	p
F	r
right-bowl	s
gamma	t
x	u
chevron	v
low-descender	y
crossed-diagonal	z
two-bars:acute	á
three-bars:acute	é
dotted-crossed-curve:acute	í
cursive-loop:acute	ó
cursive-loop:diaeresis	ö
cursive-loop:double-acute	ő
x:acute	ú
x:diaeresis	ü
x:double-acute	ű

Reproduction from a manual graphical transcription

```
python3 batches/jolanka-next-five-2026-10-12/visual-ledgers/decode.py 1217
```

This checks the original scan hash and decodes `work/as-seen.txt`, a shape-token transcription manually made from the scan and its crops. It is not OCR and is not blind: the previous reading was known. Unlike the prior editorial serializer, no plaintext-to-token program creates this ledger. Near-homographs remain {h|p} in the output; spelling expansions belong only to the normalized reading. `as-seen-provenance.json` contains the shape legend. All 19 main rows and eight stamp rows are included.

The corrected main reading has been compared to top.png and rows-12-19-detail.png, and the eight stamp rows to stamp.png. Independent full-card review is now available in review/REVIEW1.md. Its conditional acceptance permits closing after the listed corrections; no external register submission is claimed.

Response to review 1

Reviewer: Claude Opus 5.5, REVISE dated 2026-10-14. The reviewer accepted the decipherment subject to the specified corrections and requested no further review round if they were made. The following changes were checked against the original-image crops, not copied into a generated glyph ledger.

1. Corrected row 13 to és akkor jöttek: two bars give a; the final curved sign is preferred k, not the former three-stroke m. English now says “then they came from the dance school”. The residual

k/s shape ambiguity is disclosed.

2. Added the visible right bowl in row 9, giving beszel. Removed the false claim that the source omitted s.
3. Recorded the six-shaped b in row 10: Ujbesten is the literal spelling; Újpesten remains the editorial place-name normalization.
4. Corrected row 17 to eböl alt, normalized Ebből állt: “That is what my Sunday consisted of.”
5. Flagged row 8’s looped initial capital-S variant and the partly obscured n. The name Sándor is retained.
6. Kept the literal utra, ki and eze forms and their stated translation boundaries.
7. The earlier PDF was a working solver edition. It has been rebuilt with the corrections and review outcome. No watcher is started because the user explicitly instructed that sandbox watchers must not be used; markers are checked manually.

The reviewer also read Budapest’s departure postmark as 2 October 1912 and the arrival as 3 October, consistent with the catalogue date and the Jászárokszállás address. The corrected plaintext and preserved source scans remain the evidential basis; source-hash checks alone do not establish a decipherment.

Archived source provenance

HCP1217 sources

Captured 2026-10-12 through the rendered portal General, Description and Attachments tabs. Status: **Not solved**.

Portal: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1217

- picture.jpg: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3711/conversions/cpc_1912-10-02_HU__HU_Jasz-Aroksz alas_jolanka-31_pic-large.jpg ; SHA256 96c196a4331b4c98628795b61bfe16602b5ac53bbf4b7d05bd0cd9c665d37ebd
- address.jpg: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3712/conversions/cpc_1912-10-02_HU__HU_Jasz-Aroksz alas_jolanka-31_adr-large.jpg ; SHA256 a9cb7a508b252b3c85ddcb34be7b2bca0270279d15810616492b5ed69bc80815